

Topic 2: Democracy in India

Introduction:

Democracy in India marked a significant turning point in the nation's history. Following its independence from British colonial rule in 1947, India embraced a democratic framework that aimed to establish a government of the people, by the people and for the people. India's journey to democracy began with the struggle for independence, fueled by a diverse range of movements advocating for self-rule. Leaders like Mahatma Gandhi, Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar, Maulana Azad and Jawaharlal Nehru played crucial roles in shaping the vision of a democratic India, emphasizing principles such as equality, social justice, and civil rights. In 1950, India adopted its Constitution, which laid the foundation for a parliamentary democracy. The Constitution guaranteed fundamental rights to all citizens, established the separation of powers and created a framework for a representative government. This included provisions for regular elections, political participation and a robust judiciary to uphold the rule of law.

This at time India is a largest democratic country in the world. So as an Indian citizen we need to understand the Indian democracy. It is as follows:

Meaning of Democracy:

The word "democracy" comes from the Greek terms "demos" meaning "people" and "kratos" meaning "power" or "rule." Thus, democracy literally translates to "rule by the people." It refers to a system of government in which the power to make decisions is vested in the citizens, either directly or through elected representatives.

Definition of Democracy:

Democracy is a system of government in which power is held by the people, typically through elected representatives. It emphasizes principles such as political equality, individual rights, majority rule and the rule of law. In a democratic system, citizens have the right to participate in decision-making processes, often through voting in elections and engaging in civic activities. The definition of Democracy's are as follow.

1. Abraham Lincoln: "Government of the people, by the people, for the people."
2. The Oxford English Dictionary: "Democracy as a system of government in which the people have the power to make decisions, typically through elected representatives."

Types of Democracy:

There are several types of democracy, each with distinct features. The main types include:

1. **Direct Democracy:** Citizens directly participate in decision-making and law-making. This is often seen in small communities or through referendums. For example – Early Athens, Switzerland & Gramsabha in India.
2. **Indirect Democracy:** Indirect democracy is a form of government in which people elect representatives who adopt laws and make decisions on their behalf. Indirect democracy is also called representative democracy. For example – India, England, America, France, Germany etc.
3. **Representative or Parliamentary Democracy:** Citizens elect representatives to make decisions on their behalf. This is the most common form in modern states, where elected officials represent the interests of their constituents. For example – India, England, France etc.
4. **Presidential Democracy:** The presidential democracy is a form of government where the president serves as both the head of state and the head of government. This person is elected by the people and holds significant powers, overseeing the day-to-day operations of the government. For example – America (US), Armenia, Algeria, Namibia, Brazil etc.

Characteristics of Democracy:

Democracy has several key characteristics that define its functioning and principles. These include:

1. **Free and Fair Elections:** Regular, transparent elections that allow citizens to choose their representatives without coercion or manipulation.
2. **Political Equality:** All citizens have equal rights to participate in the political process, ensuring that everyone's vote carries the same weight.
3. **Rule of Law:** Laws apply equally to all individuals, and everyone, including government officials, is subject to the law.
4. **Protection of Human Rights:** Safeguarding individual freedoms, such as freedom of speech, assembly, and religion, is essential to democracy.
5. **Majority Rule and Minority Rights:** Decisions are typically made based on majority preferences, but the rights and voices of minority groups must be respected and protected.
6. **Pluralism:** Acknowledgment and acceptance of diverse opinions, beliefs, and identities within the society, fostering a rich public discourse.

7. **Accountability and Transparency:** Government actions and decisions should be open to scrutiny, allowing citizens to hold their leaders accountable.
8. **Civic Engagement:** Encouraging active participation by citizens in political processes, community discussions, and decision-making.
9. **Decentralization of Power:** Distributing power across various levels of government to prevent any single entity from becoming too powerful.

These characteristics work together to create a political environment where citizens can engage, express their views, and influence governance effectively. After independence of India accept the above constitutional Democracy.